

Cucurbita pepo (Cucurbitaceae) Pumpkin

Description Annual plant with twining stems, lobed leaves, yellow flowers, and large orange fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Probably native to North America, pumpkin is now found worldwide. It is harvested in autumn.

Parts Used Seeds, pulp.

Constituents Pumpkin seeds contain a fixed oil (30–50%), which is mostly linoleic acid (43–56%) and oleic acid (24–38%). The oil also contains protein (31–51%), sterols, cucurbitin, vitamin E, beta-carotene, and minerals (4–5%), including significant levels of iron, zinc, and selenium.

History & Folklore The pumpkin has been much used as a medicine in Central and North America. The Maya applied the sap of the plant to burns, the Menominee used the seeds as a diuretic, and European settlers ground and mixed the seeds with water, milk, or honey to make a remedy for worms. This practice became so widespread in homes across North America that the medical profession eventually adopted it as a standard treatment.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pumpkin has been used mostly as a safe and effective deworming agent, particularly in children and pregnant women for whom strong-acting and toxic preparations are inappropriate. It is thought most effective in removing tapeworms. The seeds are diuretic and tonic to the bladder; and they have distinct value in treating the early stages of prostate enlargement. The fruit pulp is used as a decoction to relieve intestinal inflammation and is applied as a poultice or plaster for burns.

Research Pumpkin seeds' range of medicinal and nutritional compounds ensures that they have great value as a "natural" food supplement. A good dietary source of zinc, the seeds also contain



Pumpkin was a popular medicinal plant in the Americas; its seeds are still used to treat worms.

relatively high levels of selenium, a mineral with important antioxidant and anticancer activity in the body. Cucurbitin repels intestinal worms, and the sterols are anti-inflammatory. Research suggests that pumpkin seed is effective in helping reduce benign enlargement of the prostate gland (BPH), due to both the hormonal influence of the sterols and this anti-inflammatory activity. In one clinical trial pumpkin seeds were combined with saw palmetto (*Serenoa repens*, p. 136) to treat BPH: those taking the herbal extract showed improved urine flow and reduced frequency of urination.

Cuminum cyminum (Apiaceae) Cumin

Description Small annual growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has long, narrow segmented leaves, clusters of pink or white flowers, and small oblong ridged fruits.

Habitat & Cultivation Cumin is native to Egypt and widely cultivated in southern Europe and Asia. The seeds are gathered when ripe in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents

Cumin seeds contain 2–5% volatile oil, which consists of 25–35% aldehydes, pinene, and alpha-terpineol. The seeds also contain flavonoids.

History & Folklore

A popular spice and medicinal herb in ancient Egypt, cumin was used for illnesses of the digestive system, for chest conditions and coughs, as a painkiller, and to treat rotten teeth. The herb is mentioned in the Old Testament and was widely used in the Middle Ages. It has declined in popularity since that time, although it is still frequently used in contemporary Egyptian herbal medicine. In cooking, cumin is an ingredient that is found in many Chinese, Indian, and Middle Eastern recipes, especially curries and pickles.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Cumin, like its close relatives caraway (*Carum carvi*, p. 184) and anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), relieves flatulence and bloating, and stimulates the entire digestive process. It reduces abdominal gases and distension and relaxes the gut. In Indian herbal medicine, cumin is used for insomnia, colds and fevers, and, mixed into a paste with onion juice, has been applied to scorpion stings. The seeds can be taken to improve breast-milk production—a role it shares with fennel seeds (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212).



Seeds

Cupressus sempervirens (Cupressaceae) Cypress

Description Evergreen tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has tiny dark green leaves, and male and female cones.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Turkey and cultivated in the Mediterranean, this herb is gathered in spring.

Parts Used Cones, branches, essential oil.

Constituents Cypress contains a volatile oil (with pinene, camphene, and cedrol) and tannins.

History & Folklore Ancient Greeks took the cones, mashed and steeped in wine, to treat dysentery, the coughing up of blood, asthma, and coughs.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Applied externally as a lotion or as a diluted essential oil, cypress astringes varicose veins and hemorrhoids, tightening up the blood vessels. A footbath of the cones is used to cleanse the feet and counter excessive sweating. Taken internally, cypress acts as an antispasmodic and general tonic, and is prescribed for whooping cough, the spitting up of blood, and spasmodic coughs.

Colds, flu, and sore throats, and rheumatic aches and pains, also benefit from this remedy.

Caution Do not take the essential oil internally without professional supervision.



Cypress has properties similar to those of witch hazel.